

MEDIAN

PHILOSOPHICAL ARCHITECTURE

The Attachment-Forward Colony Game

A top-level doctrine of genre, sanctuary, citizenship, place, risk, memory, Modes, and Registers.

**Build a sanctuary. Hazard particular friends. Bring consequence home.
Remember what happened.**

DESIGN PHILOSOPHY • DOCUMENT v1.0

I. THE GAME IN ONE BREATH

A civilization where nobody else would call home

MEDIAN is a game about the creation, endangerment, experience, and remembrance of sanctuary.

A small animal civilization makes a permanent home in the living median of an active highway. The player shapes that Home as a material, social, and historical place; sends named Citizens beyond its safety; answers what they meet; and receives their discoveries, wounds, relationships, objects, and memories back into the Colony.

The game's central dramatic promise is not conquest. It is return. The Home Median matters because someone may have to leave it, because leaving changes particular lives, and because those changes remain present when the road becomes warm, close, and familiar again.

SANCTUARY → EXPOSURE → CONSEQUENCE → RETURN → MEMORY

This rhythm binds every system. Dwell makes the Colony functional. Away makes risk personal. Return makes the two halves answer one another. Campaign Memory turns a sequence of play into the history of one particular community.

II. THE INVENTED GENRE

The attachment-forward base builder

Attachment is not an ornamental reward. It is the direction in which the design points.

Most base builders make the settlement primarily a machine, a shield, or a platform for expansion. MEDIAN treats the base as an inhabited social protagonist: one place whose systems make named lives legible and worth returning to. The Colony is not consumed by progression. Progress accumulates around it.

Orientation	The base is understood as...	Success tends toward...
Production-forward	A machine whose parts generate throughput.	Acceleration, efficiency, expansion, replacement.
Survival-forward	A defensive apparatus holding collapse at bay.	Continued existence, recovery, postponement of disaster.
Attachment-forward	A particular inhabited place with particular lives and history.	Stable ordinary life, accumulated meaning, and chosen risk on behalf of what matters.

Attachment-forward design asks a distinct question of every major mechanic: what relationship does this strengthen? A strong system usually reinforces one or more of four anchors:

- Home — the permanent place the player has made and learned.
- Citizen — a named life with prior history, present relationships, and possible future.
- Place or object — a material thing whose use and provenance become particular.
- Memory — a fact that persists because it mattered, not because it grants a modifier.

The mechanics are arranged so that the player always has someone and somewhere to come back to.

III. THE ATTACHMENT CHAIN

Sentiment must be mechanically earned

MEDIAN does not ask prose, portrait art, or charming animation to carry the entire emotional burden. Care becomes available only when the player understands the Colony, believes its safety, and has enough mental room to notice the lives inside it.

LEGIBILITY → COMPETENCE → STABILITY → ATTENTION → ATTACHMENT
ATTACHMENT → CHOSEN RISK → CONSEQUENCE → RETURN → DEEPER ATTACHMENT

This chain explains why mechanical rigor and tenderness are not opposites. A Colony that can never become comprehensible cannot become beloved. A Colony that can never become stable cannot be inhabited emotionally. A quiet day must therefore be a true success state, not merely a pause before the next compulsory failure.

Good Home play produces successful stillness.

Quiet Equilibrium is the proof that stewardship has worked. It creates room for optional ambition, observation, memory, and EMBODY. The player is not paid for quiet with another currency. The reward is that ordinary life may finally become the subject of play.

IV. THE SEVEN PILLARS

What every system must continue to serve

1. Attachment-forward base-building

The Home Median is the permanent emotional and mechanical center of the campaign. It is improved, densified, decorated, damaged, repaired, inhabited, and remembered rather than replaced. Corridor growth forms a network around Home; it does not turn Home into an obsolete tutorial settlement.

2. Named Citizens, low population, durable identity

Every Citizen is individually known. Core species and Guest origins share one equal class of citizenship. Home Roles are civic assignments, not castes or character classes. Loss, bravery, habit, relationship, disability, and inheritance matter because the population remains small enough for every name to count.

3. Ledger and legible

Important state should first be perceptible in the world and also available in clear functional form. MEDIAN rejects both opaque sentiment and spreadsheet abstraction. The player should understand what is known, what is uncertain, and why a decision matters without reducing every personal truth to a public number.

4. Expeditions make stories and enable progress

Home can sustain life; meaningful advancement requires reaching beyond it. Expeditions return material, knowledge, access, relationships, Guests, objects, and changed Citizens. Away is not an arcade interruption attached to a base. It is the dangerous horizon that makes Home consequential.

IV. THE SEVEN PILLARS — CONTINUED

Consequence, restraint, and unity

5. Consequence without disposability

Danger changes lives before it erases them. Fear, Exposure, wounds, Maiming, Distinctions, Keepsakes, After-names, separation, and altered relationships carry consequence home. Death remains possible, but Citizens are never treated as replenishable tokens or converted into salvage at the moment of loss.

6. Mechanical restraint, expressive variety

A small grammar should produce many specific meanings. New currencies, stats, menus, and subsystems are rejected when existing structures can express the decision. Variation comes from species, place, history, weather, relationships, objects, and authored context. Tabletop clarity sits beneath lived civilization.

7. One world, five Registers

DWELL, TRAVEL, RISK, MEET, and EMBODY are not separate games. They are five relationships to one persistent world. The same Citizen, Place, object, route, weather, wound, promise, or memory may appear differently in each. Transitions are emotional beats, not neutral load screens.

V. THE TWIN MODES

Home and Away are different scales of moral attention

Modes describe the game’s two fundamental conditions. They are not merely camera positions. They determine what the game treats as the primary subject of consequence.

Mode	Primary subject	Question	Promise
HOME	The Colony	How is the community arranging finite attention so ordinary life can continue?	Permanence, stewardship, sufficiency, relationship, and the possibility of quiet.
AWAY	Particular Citizens and the expedition party	Who can carry, notice, endure, choose, return, or be changed by this situation?	Distance, vulnerability, discovery, consequence, and return.

Home grows the Colony. Away grows and hazards Citizens.

At Home, a Citizen is one equal named share of civic commitment. Away, that same Citizen becomes an individually resolved bearer of capability, history, equipment, Exposure, and consequence. The distinction protects both sides: Home does not become a worker-aptitude ranking puzzle, and Away does not flatten friends into anonymous party strength.

The player may leave Home only because Home exists, and returns because Away has made something newly true. Neither Mode is complete without the other.

VI. THE FIVE REGISTERS

Registers are forms of attention

A Register answers a different question from a Mode. Mode says whether life is Home or Away. Register says what kind of attention and action the player is being asked to bring to the world. A View is only an interface expression within that relationship; it is not another Register.

Register	Verb	Player relationship	Dominant affect
Colony	DWELL	Arrange, sustain, and understand collective life.	Stewardship, familiarity, confidence.
Field	TRAVEL	Carry particular lives through extended territory.	Orientation, distance, exposure.
Crossing	RISK	Act inside immediate spatial danger after commitment.	Nerve, timing, bodily vulnerability.
Encounter	MEET	Answer a bounded circumstance with consequential choice.	Judgment, sacrifice, presence.
Embodiment	EMBODY	Experience life temporarily freed from immediate necessity.	Grace, aliveness, companionship.

MEET is cross-modal: a Colony may meet heavy wind, illness, dispute, or a stranger; an expedition may meet a blocked route, resource, predator, or demand. EMBODY is deliberately Home-only. Temporary calm abroad is not sanctuary. Sanctuary is a material and social condition produced by a functioning Home.

**Danger makes sanctuary necessary. DWELL makes sanctuary functional.
EMBODY makes sanctuary felt. Memory makes sanctuary personal.**

VII. CITIZENSHIP AND BODILY CIVILIZATION

A Citizen is a life, not a slot

Every named arrival already belongs to a life before they belong to the Colony. Citizenship does not create personhood. Core species define the three complete civilizational forms; Guest species reveal whom this particular Colony has chosen to welcome. Once present, all are equal Citizens under the same architecture.

At Home, equality means one named share of civic commitment rather than personal productivity ratings. Away, individuality returns through body, history, Tools, Keepsakes, relationships, fear, and experience. Home function and Away identity are allowed to be unrelated because a life is larger than a job.

Three bodily ideas of safety

Mouse, Rabbit, and Squirrel are not cosmetic factions or stat packages. Their bodies read the same median as different topologies. Civilization begins when a bodily instinct is translated into architecture, custom, and promise.

Species	Placement verb	Bodily question	Civilizational promise
Mouse	JOIN	What can I remain in contact with?	There is room for you under our roof.
Rabbit	GATHER	How quickly can I disappear into shared safety?	We will make another neighborhood for you.
Squirrel	CONNECT	What can I reach from here, and by how many ways?	We will bring you into reach.

Ecology determines what safety feels like. Culture determines what civilization builds from it.

VIII. THE WORLD AND ITS TONE

The highway is not scenery

MEDIAN takes place inside active human infrastructure, not after its abandonment. Traffic continues. Maintenance continues. Noise, runoff, heat, salt, wind, vibration, barriers, drainage, verge growth, and human work continually reorganize animal life. The highway is barrier, climate, resource edge, and ecological organizer at once.

The Median is therefore a moral and spatial paradox: a strip designed as nobody’s destination becomes a permanent polity. Human scale remains vast, mostly indifferent, and only partly legible. The animals do not conquer that world or reproduce it in miniature. They make a non-industrial scrap culture inside its seams.

MEDIAN seeks...	Rather than...
Sanctuary	“Cozy” safety detached from credible material conditions.
Peril	Combat fantasy or heroic violence as the primary solution.
Civilization	Miniature human industrialization, electricity fantasy, or factory chains.
Tenderness	Sentimentality that demands a buff, reward, or compulsory emotional response.
Legibility	A spreadsheet that hides the inhabited world behind menus.
Quiet	Emptiness, inactivity, or the absence of meaningful play.

Open to the player is not open to the world.

Visual clarity may reveal rooms, routes, courts, and connections that would be concealed in literal animal life. This is a representational privilege, not a diegetic fact. The player must be able to understand the civilization in order to care for it.

IX. DESIGN GUIDELINES

Guardrails for keeping MEDIAN itself

Protect attachment chains. A new mechanic should strengthen relationship to Home, a Citizen, a Place or object, or Campaign Memory. Mere feature density is not progress.

Make quiet mechanically credible. The Colony must be able to become genuinely stable. Endless entropy prevents the player from noticing the life they are protecting.

Protect player attention. Use clear accounting boundaries, compressed state, and situated scenes. Do not turn ordinary stewardship into continuous alarm management.

Keep Home collective and Away particular. Do not import personal aptitude ranking into Home or reduce Away consequence to anonymous party math.

Let important consequences become local. Persistent capacities may remain global; moments that matter should belong to a particular Citizen, Place, relationship, object, or scene.

Use existing grammar before inventing a subsystem. A small number of strong mechanics should carry many manifestations. Do not create a currency, meter, menu, or exception simply because an edge case can be imagined.

Do not canonize impossible interface actions. When the game never offers an option, no further negative rule is required. Design the available choice cleanly and let absence remain absence.

Care must not become a buff economy. The player should sometimes attend to a Citizen because that life matters, not because attention is the optimal resource engine.

Memory need not be progression. A fact may remain meaningful without becoming a statistic, bonus, collectible, or unlock.

Comparability is not convergence. When a familiar genre feature appears commercially legible, ask which MEDIAN value its conventional form would erase before adopting it.

X. THE PLAYER'S POSITION

Steward, witness, and chooser of risk

The player is not principally a commander, mayor, production optimizer, or possessed avatar. The player occupies several ethical positions in sequence:

- Steward — arrange finite civic attention so the Colony can function and become safe.
- Chooser — decide when a need or ambition justifies sending particular friends beyond sanctuary.
- Witness — remain present when consequence belongs to a named life, not an abstract unit.
- Companion — in EMBODY, accompany rather than possess; guide attention while the Citizen retains expression.
- Rememberer — preserve what mattered without converting every emotional fact into advantage.

This player position is the moral center of MEDIAN. Power is real but incomplete. The player can build, assign, prepare, choose, and answer. The player cannot erase bodily vulnerability, command affection, guarantee return, or make a life meaningful solely by optimizing it.

The Colony is the social protagonist. The Citizens are the lives through whom its meaning becomes particular.

Closing proposition

MEDIAN is a base builder in which the highest achievement is not a larger machine but a more inhabited world. Its systems exist to make sanctuary credible, danger personal, return consequential, and memory cumulative. The player should finish a campaign not merely knowing what was built, but knowing who lived there, what the place became, who left it, who returned, and why the quiet was worth earning.

THE OTHER REGISTERS EXPLAIN HOW SMALL LIVES ARE ORGANIZED, CARRIED, ENDANGERED, AND CONFRONTED.

EMBODY EXPLAINS WHY PRESERVING THEM IS WORTH DOING.